

Lesson 4-1

Types and Characteristics of Media

Learning Objectives

- Compare the characteristics of different media, and explain the strengths and constraints of websites.
- Choose suitable media for a given purpose and audience, and justify the choice.

Before building a website, it helps to ask: why a website at all? TV reaches millions at once but only one way. Radio can be received almost anywhere but conveys sound only. A newspaper lasts on paper without the Internet. A website combines text, images, and video, updates at any time, and can even respond through forms — while SNS (social networking services) spreads news the fastest of all. Each medium has its own strengths and constraints, so the smart choice depends on the message and the audience.

? Guiding question: What are the strengths and constraints of different media, and how do you choose the right one for a purpose and audience?

Key Fact:
Each medium has different strengths and constraints; choosing the right medium — often several combined — depends on the purpose and the target audience.

Key Concepts:

- TV / radio / newspaper
- website / SNS
- one-way / two-way
- strengths / constraints
- combining media

KEY TERMS
one-way — from sender to receiver only.
two-way — users can respond and share.

Point!

1. Comparison of the Characteristics of Different Media

(1) Each medium for conveying information has different characteristics. When planning a website, it is important to understand the differences from other media.

Medium	Information conveyed	Characteristics
TV	Video + audio	Reaches many people simultaneously. Appeals to sight and hearing. One-way, from sender to receiver.
Radio	Audio	Appeals only to hearing. Can be received almost anywhere and alongside other tasks. One-way.
Newspaper	Text + images	Remains physically as a printed medium. Can be read without an Internet connection. One-way.
Website	Text + images + video + audio	Diverse information can be combined. Can be updated at any time. Basically one-way, but two-way interaction is also possible through forms, comments, etc.
SNS	Text + images + video + audio	Highly effective at spreading information rapidly. Users can post and share information. Two-way.

2. Strengths and Constraints of Websites

(1) Strengths of websites

① Diverse information such as text, images, and video can be combined and presented.

② Information can be updated at any time.

③ Can be accessed from almost anywhere in the world.

④ Two-way interaction with users is possible through forms, comments, etc.

⑤ Can be used with just a browser; no dedicated app installation is required.



Traditional and digital media, side by side.

(2) Constraints of websites

① Normally requires an Internet connection (unless the page is cached).

② Information does not reach users unless they actively access it.

③ Display and loading speed may differ depending on the user's device and network environment.



A website combines strengths one-way media lack.

PAUSE & THINK

Which medium would you choose to reach the most people at once — and which to let them respond to you?

3. Choosing Media According to Purpose

(1) When conveying information, it is important to choose the most suitable medium according to the purpose and target audience.

Purpose	Examples of suitable media	Reason
Inform many people at once	TV, SNS ads	Wide reach
Provide detailed information	Website	No limit on information volume; can be viewed at any time
Deliver information directly to specific people	Email, direct messages	Can be delivered individually
Spread by word of mouth	SNS	Users can voluntarily share and spread information



Match the medium to the purpose and audience.

(2) In practice, multiple media are often used in combination.
e.g., A TV commercial directs viewers to a website, and the website encourages spreading information through SNS.

✎ Worked Example

(1) Mark each statement (A–D) with ○ if true or × if false.

A A website can present diverse information such as text, images, and video in combination.

B TV is a medium that allows two-way interaction with users.

C SNS is a medium highly effective at spreading information rapidly.

D A website normally can be viewed even without an Internet connection.

(2) Match each purpose (a–c) with the most suitable medium from the choices below (A–C).

a Make detailed information viewable at any time

b Have users spread information by word of mouth

c Inform many people at once with video

[Choices] **A** TV **B** Website **C** SNS

✓ Solution

(1)

A Correct as a strength of websites. Therefore, ○.

B TV is a one-way medium from sender to receiver. Therefore, ×.

C Correct description of the characteristics of SNS. Therefore, ○.

D A website normally requires an Internet connection. Therefore, ×.

(2)

a: A website allows detailed information to be viewed at any time. **B**

b: SNS spreads easily by word of mouth. **C**

c: TV reaches many people with video. **A**

Try

1 Answer the following questions.

1. Name two strengths of websites.
2. Name two constraints of websites.

2 Answer the following questions.

(1) From the following options (A–D), choose the one that is NOT an appropriate characteristic of websites.

A Information can be updated at any time.

B Information automatically reaches users without them actively accessing it.

C Text, images, and video can be combined and presented.

D Two-way interaction is possible through forms and comments.

(2) For each situation (a–d), indicate which medium is most suitable: **A** TV, **B** Website, **C** SNS, **D** Email.

a Make the detailed specifications and usage of a new product available at any time.

b Have users spread information about a new product by word of mouth.

c Deliver video of a new product to many people at once.

d Send campaign information directly to existing customers.

⚙ Think as an Engineer — Investigate & Decide

A public library in your city wants to tell people about a new free reading program. You advise on which media to use.

☐ **Use one medium only** ☐ **Combine media by purpose**

1 · Collect data. Survey ten classmates or family members: where do they actually notice local announcements — a printed poster, Facebook,

EXAM-STYLE QUESTION

Explain why an organization might use a website, TV, and SNS together rather than only one, to promote a new service. **[6] Refer to:** reach, depth, and spreading by word of mouth.

PAUSE & THINK

For each situation below, ask first: is the goal wide reach, full detail, spreading, or a direct message?

WhatsApp, or local radio? Record the results in a table and find the most common channel.

2 · Analyze the audience. For each group — a family with no home Internet, a student, and the librarian — note one benefit and one drawback of using a website as the library's main channel.

3 · Decide. Using your survey and your table, recommend a media plan (which media, in what roles) and give two reasons. **In pairs,** compare your plans and agree together on the single best medium for reaching families who may not be online.

Give evidence for your answer.

Stuck? Start from the audience your survey shows is hardest to reach — which medium already reaches them where they are?

🌍 In a New Context

A hospital wants to inform patients about new opening hours and let them ask questions. Name one medium for reaching many people quickly and one that allows two-way interaction, and say why each one fits.

❓ Lesson Question — Answered

The lesson asked about the strengths and constraints of different media and how to choose. Each medium has its own character: TV reaches many at once but one-way; radio is sound only but reaches anywhere; a newspaper lasts on paper without the Internet; a website combines text, images, and video, updates any time, and allows two-way interaction, though it needs an Internet connection and only reaches those who seek it; and SNS spreads information fastest and is two-way. Because no single medium is best for everything, the right choice depends on the purpose and the target audience — wide reach, full detail, direct delivery, or word-of-mouth — and in practice several media are combined so each does what it does best.

KEY TERMS

website strengths — diverse, updatable, global, two-way.

website constraints — needs Internet; users must seek it.

Exercise

1 Cover the Point! section with a red plastic sheet and quiz yourself in your notebook in numerical order.

2 Read the following passage and answer each question.

Each medium for conveying information has different characteristics. A website has the strengths of being able to present diverse information such as text, images, and video, and being updatable at any time. On the other hand, it has the constraints that it cannot be viewed without an (a) connection, and that information does not reach users unless they actively (b) it. In actual information dissemination, (c) media are often combined, such as directing viewers from a TV commercial to a website.

1. Fill in the blanks (a)–(c).

3 Answer the following questions.

(1) From the following options (A–D), choose the one that most appropriately describes the characteristics of media.

A Radio is a medium that conveys information through video and audio.

B Newspapers are media highly effective at spreading information rapidly.

C SNS is a medium that allows users to post and share information.

D TV is a medium that allows two-way interaction with users.

(2) From the following options (A–D), choose the one that most appropriately describes the choice of media.

A Information dissemination should always use only one medium.

B Regardless of purpose or target audience, a website is sufficient.

C It is important to choose the most suitable medium according to the purpose and target audience.

D With SNS, TV and websites are not needed.

REFLECT & CHALLENGE

Reflect: Which medium do you personally trust most for important news, and why?
Challenge: Plan the media mix for announcing a school event on a budget that rules out TV — then name one audience your mix might still miss, and why.

Key takeaway

Remember:
No medium is best for everything — match the medium to the purpose and audience, and combine media so each does what it does best.